



of history as in those histories that celebrated the progress of technology, enterprise, and liberal democracy. It did not necessarily imply optimism—there were numerous prophets of decline and doom. But it did suggest that essentially history had been made, and was still being made, by Europe. For instance, it was deemed acceptable for respected European historians to maintain that Africa had no significant history at all, having failed to contribute to the onward march of humanity.

Post-colonial revisionism

In the second half of the 20th century, the notion of a single, historical “grand narrative” collapsed, taking Eurocentrism with it. The postcolonial, postmodernist world was seen as requiring a multiplicity of histories told from the points of view of many different social identities. There was a surge of interest in the study of black history, women’s history, and gay history, as well as histories narrated from an Asian, African, or American Indian standpoint. The marginal and oppressed in society were reassessed as “agents” of history rather than passive victims.

A riot of revisionism upturned much of the history of the world as commonly known to educated people in the West, although often without putting any satisfactory alternative version in place of the old. For example, the puzzlement that resulted can be seen in the response to the 500th anniversary in 1992 of Christopher Columbus’s first voyage to the Americas. It would once have been expected to excite widespread celebration

in the United States, but was in practice acknowledged with some embarrassment, if at all. People are no longer sure what to think about traditional history, its Great Men, and its epoch-making events.

A 21st-century perspective

The Little Book of History reflects this abandonment of “grand narratives” of human progress. It aims to present a general reader with an overview of world history through specific events, which can act as windows upon selected areas of the past. In line with contemporary concerns, this book also reflects the long-term importance of key factors such as population growth, climate, and the environment throughout history. At the same time, it gives an account of matters of popular historical interest, such as the Magna Carta and the American Civil War.

The book begins with the origins of humans and “prehistory” and progresses through different historical ages to the present day. In reality, of course, there were no such clear breaks between epochs, and where there is an overlap on dates, entries are included in the appropriate ideological era.

As this book illustrates, history is a process rather than a series of unconnected events. We can only speculate on how the events we experience today will shape the history of tomorrow. No one in the early 21st century can possibly claim to make sense of history, but it remains the fundamental discipline for anyone who believes, as the poet Alexander Pope did, that “the proper study of Mankind is Man.” ■